

Empathy: The Pursuit of Joy

A FILM BY DR. NATALIE PETOUHOFF

Dr. Natalie Petouhoff

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What settles a nun in meditation and a man in a maximum- security cell?

We went looking — from the Dalai Lama's monasteries in Dharamshala to a chaplaincy at Rikers Island — and found the same ar

both rooms.



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THE PROBLEM

The wise choice doesn't lose on merit. It loses at **the moment of need.**

The engineered fix

Stress, loneliness, numbness — and always within reach, a perfectly engineered fix: the scroll, the drink, the cart. Instant. Personalized. Frictionless. These aren't bad habits; they're the most sophisticated behavioral technology ever built — engineered for nervous systems that are already cornered.

The undelivered medicine

Contemplative practice wins the same moment, and has for three thousand years. It builds what the quick fixes only counterfeit: agency, meaning, connection. It just never got a delivery system.

Everyone is selling self-regulation in fragments. This film is the definitive translation.

Meditation apps, breathwork, cold plunges, gratitude journals, sound baths — they are all teaching self-regulation. Essentially Buddhism, branded differently. Even the scroll, the drink, the cart: attempts at self-regulation that don't work. People feel crappy and they just want to feel better.

The barrier isn't belief — it's translation. People never receive this wisdom in a form their skepticism, their nervous system, or their worst moment can accept. This project builds the translation layer — empathy as the method, science as the passport — and delivers the felt shift — the shift you can feel. Not a film about meditation. The delivery system the medicine never had.

The ancients had the insight.
What's new is *the instrument*.

Measurable regulation

Before/after neuroscience on real audiences:
watch it happen in your own body and brain.

Personalized feedback

The adoption lever the wellness industry
never had.

Format science

Testing what the nervous system will actually
accept: story, sound, rhythm, synchrony, breath.

This film could
not have been
made twenty years
ago. The wisdom
is ancient; *the
proof is brand new.*

Four transformational elements. One **elixir**.

A five-element storytelling architecture: Buddhist wisdom traditions · Jungian psychology · the Hero's Journey · modern neuroscience — and the fifth element, empathy, the integrative force that lets perception shift. The most underrated tool of personal actualization.

Empathy is the new meditation

Meditation only reached the West when it was repositioned as universal, scientific, non-religious. This film applies the same translational move to empathy: from misunderstood emotion to measurable core human technology — oxytocin up, cortisol down, self- and co-regulation restored.

25 years of proof

The Dalai Lama has collaborated with neuroscientists at Harvard, Stanford, Wisconsin, Columbia, UCSD, and Emory for over 25 years. Emory's compassion-measurement program has trained 77M+ people in 24 countries — with measured outcomes in stress, depression, anxiety, and anti-stress biomarkers.

THE WORK

A 90-minute feature **and**
a series. A new category:
therapeutic entertainment.

Real people — monks and maximum-security
prisoners, doctors, artists, mothers, fathers —
facing life's beautiful, brutal, in-between.

Every piece is both medicine and instrument: documentary segments,
original score, breath-paced and binaural sound, contemplative visual art
— built, measured, revised, tested. We don't make media and hope. We
run a measured intervention with a film as its instrument.

THE WORK

A 90-minute feature **and** a series. A new category: therapeutic entertainment. — continued



THE WORK

A 90-minute feature **and** a series. A new category: therapeutic entertainment. — continued

► WATCH THE TRAILER

Assembled and already shooting.

Dr. Natalie Petouhoff

Executive Producer, Writer, Story Architect. WSJ bestselling author (Empathy in Action, 15 industry awards), PhD scientist (UCLA). The through-line: proving the soft thing can be measured — first for business, now for being human.

Josh Sikkema

Director-Cinematographer. Award-winning filmmaker (8 festival wins for Something in the Clouds); collaborations spanning Snoop Dogg, Jimmy Jam & Terry Lewis — 1B+ streams. Crain's 40 Under 40.

Maejor

Musical Director, Sonic Architect. Multi-platinum, Grammy-nominated; producer on Justin Bieber's 2025 album Swag; Van Gogh: The Immersive Experience; founder, Frequency Music School. Recording studio at the Dalai Lama's school.

THE TEAM

Assembled and **already shooting.** — continued



From production — the monk-and-scientist sessions

What survives a skeptical room.

The measurement plan is written and submitted: every element of the film — segments, narration, original music, chanting, breath-paced sound, neuroacoustic and binaural elements, contemplative visual art, guided reflection — is treated as a research stimulus, alone and in combination. Prototyped, measured, revised, tested.

What we measure

Effects on self-regulation and co-regulation — for individuals, couples, families, friends, and communities — short- and long-term, and why.

What it builds

A replicable evidence base for artists, contemplative teachers, educators, and community leaders — showing how their work changes lives, for whom, and under what conditions. Sponsor-ready case studies, third-party validated.

The audience is already in the room.

A worldwide network — researchers, well-being organizations, practitioners, educators, artists, community leaders — is screening prototypes and shaping the work right now. They are our collaborators. When the film is ready, they are our distributors.

The audience is **already in the room.** — continued

The question every
producer fears
— “will anyone
watch?” — was
answered *before
a frame was shot.*

Event-based community screenings, curricula, and measured impact
outlive the release window.

Eight streams. One engine.

Screenings

Event-based, measured, community-hosted.

Curriculum

Licensing to schools, orgs, corporate well-being.

Sound-bath audio

Subscription soundtrack — binaural, breath-paced.

Experiences

Music + wellbeing events and retreats — recurring, return-customer, not a one-time museum piece. Network partners ready: Taylor Renee (LA event producer, LCSC.LA), Jimmy Bell (DJ — events & retreats).

Apparel + fan funding

Empathy-brand apparel — neuroscience-curated materials, with collaborator Suz (dinoapparel.com botanic line). Community pre-commitment.

Book + paper

Authority engine feeding every other stream.

Plus immersive installation and traditional distribution (SVOD · AVOD/FAST · TVOD). Conservative projections per the project one-sheet: revenue \$0.25M (2026) → \$5.2M (2031), EBITDA-positive from 2027.

Three tiers. Each complete on its own.

1

PROOF

Completion funds — finish the feature, complete the measurement round, DIFF premiere + festival and impact-screening run.

\$850K

2

TRANSLATION

+ scientifically-composed soundtrack, vertical content engine, series pilot package.

\$1-1.5M

3

CATEGORY

+ series order package, immersive experience build, Experiences program, global screening + curriculum rollout.

\$2-3M

Four lanes open: grants (Templeton Foundation proposal, submitted July 2026) · equity · brand sponsorship · tax-deductible donations via fiscal sponsor From the Heart Productions (501c3). How to Be a Good Human, a Delaware Public Benefit Corporation. Final budget detail available under NDA.

Where the money **works**.

Make the work

Final Dharamshala shoots — the powerful women of the Dalai Lama's inner circle, His Holiness's message for the film, the student recording studio. US shoots — the Dalai Lama's neuroscientists, the Rikers Island chaplaincy. Music — original score and sonic-healing architecture, licensing, production.

Carry the work

Post-production to Netflix delivery readiness — edit, color, sound design. Third-party health-impact measurement with sponsor-ready case studies. Social impact campaign, DIFF sponsorship, global marketing prep. Impact philanthropy: sponsoring children in exile, the student studio, their music in the film. Detailed line budget under NDA.

THE SUMMONS

The film is a **reboot**. Join us.

“Not because
I’m right —
but because of
how the human
operating system
is designed.”

— Dr. Natalie Petouhoff

Empathy: The Pursuit of Joy · Ancient wisdom, proven by science · Film
completion Aug '26 · Premiere: Dalai Lama's Dharamshala International
Film Festival (DIFF), Nov '26 · Our journey — and now yours.